Aashish Chhabra

Platform Engineering & Architecture Leader

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Right to work: requires Skilled Worker visa sponsorship (UK) or equivalent work authorisation (EU).

PERSONAL PROFILE

Platform engineering and architecture leader with 12+ years of experience, from application development through large-scale data platform administration to designing the automation, security and platform products other engineering teams depend on. Personally built a central CI/CD framework connecting 170+ repositories to automated, centrally secured pipelines; service owner and technical lead of Kafka-as-a-Service, a managed multi-tenant Kafka platform for Airtel B2B Cloud customers. Line and functional leader across Development and DevOps who remains hands-on.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Senior Lead Engineer, Data Techops (DGM), Xtelify Limited (the Airtel engineering organisation; formerly Bharti Airtel Limited)

December 2024 – Present | Gurugram, India

- Personally built and maintain, with my team, a central marker-file-driven CI/CD framework: a repository needs only a small marker file to be wired automatically into shared build, test and security-scan pipelines. It serves 170+ repositories across many projects and business lines.
- Moved image security scanning from Prisma Cloud to Wiz across 170+ repositories in one central change, with no repository-level work for developers; Black Duck and Coverity continue to run alongside it.
- Service owner and technical lead of Kafka-as-a-Service, a managed multi-tenant Kafka platform for Airtel B2B Cloud customers: architecture, technology choices (React, Smithy, Java Spring Boot, Temporal, PostgreSQL, Redis, Helm, Argo CD), pull-request reviews, security analysis and service readiness.
- Implemented OpenTelemetry for Kafka-as-a-Service observability, alongside Prometheus, Grafana and Elastic monitoring of the service and the clusters it creates.
- Contribute to the architecture and packaging of CDE (Converged Data Engine), Airtel's in-house Data Mesh platform, as a B2B Cloud service, covering the cloud environment, networks, sign-in integration and customer readiness.
- Provide line and functional leadership across Development and DevOps: hiring and interviewing, performance reviews, talent discussions and technical direction.
- Use Claude Code for pull-request review, security and bug analysis, and frontend/backend consistency checks; lead the introduction of AI-assisted engineering practices across the team.

Lead Engineer, Bharti Airtel Limited, then Xtelify Limited (same organisation; legal-entity change in August 2024)

June 2021 – November 2024 | Gurugram, India

- Engineered and ran a Kafka platform on 9 bare-metal brokers carrying about 40 Gbps of combined traffic (bytes in plus bytes out, including replication), taking in streaming data from across India.
- Automated cluster creation with Python and Ansible, ran Kerberos and SCRAM sign-in on separate ports, added Cruise Control rebalancing, Grafana dashboards and phone alerts, and tuned the operating system (network buffers, interrupt handling, file-handle limits) to keep up with traffic.
- Set Airtel's Elastic Stack monitoring standards (central logging, centrally managed agents on VMs, bare metal and Kubernetes, application tracing) and drove adoption before handing it on.
- Led and contributed to moving applications from Docker Swarm and server installs to OpenShift; deployed Helm charts, troubleshot production container workloads and hardened them with security contexts.
- Set up Spark Operator, Trino (community Helm charts, company sign-in) and JupyterHub (LDAP sign-in) for developer teams.

- Worked with security and development teams to add vulnerability scanning to build pipelines, and designed an early single-workflow CI/CD approach (2023) that was later rebuilt into the central framework.

Senior Software Engineer, Bharti Airtel Limited

September 2019 – May 2021 | Gurugram, India

- Sole administrator of the production Cloudera platform as it grew from about 15 to about 390 servers: installation, configuration, upgrades, repairs and capacity growth.
- Planned and worked on the migration from CDH 5.8 to CDP 7.1.6 with developers and operations, and planned and executed the replacement of the NameNode server with no business downtime.
- Planned and deployed disaster recovery for the production platform.
- Automated daily housekeeping with Python, shell scripts, Ansible, Jenkins and Airflow schedules.

Senior Software Engineer, NCR Corporation

January 2018 – September 2019 | Gurugram, India

- Built and ran an Enterprise Data Lake on Hortonworks HDP end to end: cluster installs and upgrades, Kerberos with Active Directory, Ranger access policies, and on-call support.
- Kept data flowing with Sqoop ingestion from relational databases (ATM, self-checkout and point-of-sale data), Hive transformations and automated Hive partition repair.

Software Engineer (Associate Software Engineer until June 2015), Tech Mahindra

June 2014 – December 2017 | Pune, India

- Built Java and JSP application screens and SQL reporting logic for an AT&T quotations system (client work for Amdocs and AT&T).
- Member of the pilot that moved quotations data into Hadoop (Sqoop, Hive, Pig), then worked on the follow-on AT&T Quotations Warehouse System: took part in cluster planning and built ingestion, Hive transformations and Oozie workflows.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Platform & Data: Apache Kafka, Cloudera CDH/CDP, Hortonworks HDP, Apache Hive, Sqoop, Spark Operator, Trino, YARN, Zookeeper, Apache Airflow

CI/CD & Security: Jenkins, Central CI/CD framework (marker-file driven), Argo CD, Helm, Ansible, Black Duck, Coverity, Wiz, Temporal

Containers & Cloud: OpenShift (OCP), Kubernetes, Docker, Docker Swarm, Airtel B2B Cloud, Microsoft Azure (AZ-900 certified)

Observability: Elastic Stack (ELK), Prometheus, Grafana, OpenTelemetry, Kafka UI

Languages & Data Stores: Python, Java, Shell, SQL, PostgreSQL, Redis, MySQL, SQL Server

Frameworks: Java Spring Boot, React, Smithy, Pandas

Systems: RHEL/CentOS, Kernel tuning, Systemd, Kerberos, Ranger, Active Directory and LDAP integration

AI-Assisted Engineering: Claude Code, GitHub Copilot, Cursor

CERTIFICATIONS & TRAINING

Hortonworks HDP Certified Developer (2017); Microsoft Azure Fundamentals, AZ-900 (2024); IIM Indore, Management Development Programme (2024)

EDUCATION

B.Tech, Electronics and Communication Engineering. Global Institute of Technology, Jaipur (Rajasthan Technical University, Kota), 2010 – 2014